

1790–1800

NEOCLASSICISM

The fashions of the last decade of the 18th century reflected a time of upheaval and change. It brought more informal dress, inspired by country rather than court styles, and influenced by revolutionary fervour in France. Wrapping gowns in striped silk and painted chintzes gave way to printed cottons and plain cotton chemise dresses that could, at last, be washed. Imported Indian calicos and muslins were popular for neckerchiefs and full-length dresses. By 1800 white predominated. The shape was a neoclassical columnar silhouette, with a simple, high-waisted dress. There was little understructure except for an opaque linen shift and cotton underslip that echoed the shape of the gown, and sometimes half-stays to support the bust. Hand-stitched seams were neat and unobtrusive. Accessories added colourful highlights. Extraordinary features emerged: like the audacious revealing of thighs through flimsy muslins, laced corsets worn on top of dresses, and red ribbon that may have signified veiled support for the revolutionaries.



1799

Overtunic embroidery White cotton dresses were fastened with ties, or Dorset (yarn-covered) buttons, and often had drawstring necklines. This sleeveless, trained overtunic is secured on the shoulders, toga-style.

Outer wear Fur muffs added warmth for women suffering for the whims of fashion, as did satin and velvet tabards, and bearskin-fur tippets. Close-fitting headwear covered shorter hair.



1790

Straw bonnet This morning gown has an overdress of delicate striped print. A buffon neckerchief folded into a triangle and puffed up under the chin crosses over at the front and ties behind. Half-stays still support the bosom.



Laced bodice Neoclassical meets avant-garde in the dress (left) with external front-laced corset. Accents of colour are introduced to the dress (right) through the use of red ribbon trim.